Mecca, at a time when the Mughal women's party would have been directly concerned. The royal ladies finally reached Mecca in time to participate in the pilgrimage of 1577 following which they performed the hajj three more times. According to Badauni they also undertook many lesser pilgrimages and visited the important Shia shrines of Karbala, Qum, and Mashhad in addition to Mecca.

In 1581, once the Mughal ladies were safely back on Hindustani soil, Akbar inexplicably stopped sending the hajj caravans and the annual alms to Mecca. For six years Akbar had patronized the sending of a mir hajj, and hajj ships, and had subsidized all pilgrims at great expense, and now he forbade pilgrims from going to Mecca altogether. It has been argued that this was in line with his veering away from orthodox Islamic practices and while it is true that other practices, such as the Ajmer pilgrimage, were also discontinued, Akbar was a pragmatic man. If he did not participate in the Ajmer pilgrimage himself he sent the royal princes in lieu, to keep orthodox sentiments appeased. The withdrawal of ships and money to Mecca appear to have been motivated by a personal and sharp sliver of anger at the high-handedness of the Ottoman authorities and what would have been perceived as disrespect towards Akbar's beloved family members. There was certainly a moment of imperial frisson between the descendant of Suleiman the Magnificent, and Akbar the Great. So violent now would be Akbar's reaction at any perceived slight from the Ottomans that in 1582 he would put the Ottoman ambassador in chains and send him 'for a long period to Lahore' while the embassy itself 'vanished in a cloud of smoke' for a supposed excess of arrogance.

Gulbadan brought back with her an iron detestation of the Portuguese, whom she complained about bitterly, and she even tried to encourage the locals to take back the town of Baksar once she had returned to Surat. This hatred of the rapacious Portuguese was widespread and 'the mere name of Christian or Frank', noted Monserrate sadly, when returning to Goa in 1582, 'is horrible and hateful'. There would be no more hajj ships sent by Akbar, though Jahangir would reinstate this custom and the next ships to be sent on hajj would be under the patronage of his mother, the Rajput princess, Harkha Bai, after she had become the queen mother. Reborn as Maryam uz Zamani she would send 1,700 pilgrims on hajj in 1619. But for Akbar, Padshah of Hindustan, ruling over an empire with a population five